NON-STARTER Punjab Lok Congress chief Capt. Amarinder with wife Preneet Kaur at a road show in Patiala



the party's in-charge for elections in Punjab, says, "There is no doubt that today's results have made the AAP the fastest growing political party ever in the history of Indian politics. Today, we are a national party, a force to reckon with nationally. No other party has achieved this status. It is not for the AAP to decide whether to fight Gujarat, Himachal, it is for the people of those states to decide whether they want AAP in their state or not." AAP can now send five members to the Rajya Sabha from Punjab when elections to the Upper House are held later this summer.

AAP has already spread its wings in Chandigarh, getting 14 members elected to the local corporation in a 35-member house. Similarly, two partymen got elected in Goa. But for their soaring ambitions to take flight, Mann will have to perform. With a full government in Punjab, AAP can now work to make an example of their governance model, and launch Kejriwal as a national leader. In his address to a public gathering in Delhi on results day (March 10), Kejriwal invoked the words of freedom fighter Bhagat Singh: "Nothing changes if the system doesn't change...." Mann will have to become that change.

WITH A FULL GOVERNMENT IN PUNJAB, AAP WILL HOPE TO MAKE AN EXAMPLE OF THEIR GOVERNANCE MODEL AND LAUNCH KEJRIWAL AS A NATIONAL LEADER

With Punjab's cumulative debt almost touching Rs 2.82 lakh crore, Mann faces serious challenges. In the past five years, Punjab added debt of Rs 1 lakh crore. Adding to Mann's worries, from June onwards, the Centre is not obliged to provide GST compensation. The state is still falling short of the targeted revenues from GST by 20-odd per cent. Mann's critics point to his lack of administrative experience in the face of such serious issues.

Unlike Kejriwal in Delhi, Mann will also not have the luxury of a surplus budget. Apart from encouraging crop diversification to address the state's agricultural crisis, he will have to find the means to incentivise industries in Punjab. The recent farm unions' protests have already discouraged private investors from betting big on Punjab; Mann will have to look for ways to popularise crop diversification with public money.

But his biggest challenge will be to strike a balance among the politically dominant Jat Sikhs, Dalits and upper-caste Hindus, while making sure that a perception is not created that he is being tutored by the party high command in Delhi. For this, he can take cues from Amarinder, who despite being a Congress CM, ran Punjab like a regional outfit. He differed with the high command on various issues like construction of the Sutlej-Yamuna link canal, free power to the farmers etc. Similarly, Mann too may have to confront Kejriwal's Delhi government on issues such as stubble burning and water sharing.

Along with this, Mann will have to tread lightly on *panthic* issues. The near wipeout of the Akali Dal has opened doors for AAP in the Shiromani Gurudwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) and Sikh politics to further marginalise Sukhbir Badal. This is the first time since Operation Blue Star that SAD is almost out of state politics and the Congress too is weak. Meanwhile, on the national security front, pro-Khalistan groups including the Simranjit Mann-led Shiromani Akali Dal (Amritsar) garnered some 5 per cent of the vote. While dealing with them democratically, Mann will have to reassure Hindu voters who took a chance on AAP.

Law and order issues, the smuggling of arms across the border, inter-state disputes of irrigation and dams, and the transfer of the Union territory of Chandigarh to Punjab are among the standing crop of challenges that will test the new chief minister as he takes charge of the state that was once India's showpiece of rural prosperity and progress. A perilous task and an unprecedented opportunity for Mann and his party. ■